

How to Photograph Your Craft: Beginner's Guide

You Don't Need an Expensive Camera

A modern smartphone camera is more than capable of producing beautiful product photos. What matters more than equipment is light, background, and composition.

The Golden Rule: Natural Light

The single most important thing you can do is use natural daylight. Find a window that gets good indirect light (not direct sun, which creates harsh shadows). The best time is usually mid-morning on an overcast day.

What to avoid: overhead ceiling lights (yellow cast), flash (flat and harsh), direct sunlight (blown-out highlights).

Backgrounds That Work

- A large sheet of white or cream card from an art shop (£2-3)
- Natural wood, slate, or stone surfaces
- Linen or cotton fabric — cream, grey, or natural tones
- Avoid busy patterns or bright colours that compete with your product

The 3-Shot Formula for Every Product

Shot 1 — The hero shot: Straight-on or slight angle, clean background, product filling 60% of the frame. This is your main listing photo.

Shot 2 — The detail shot: Move in close to show texture, craftsmanship, or a key feature. This builds trust.

Shot 3 — The lifestyle shot: Product in use or in context — a mug on a kitchen table, a basket in a hallway. This helps buyers imagine it in their home.

Simple Editing on Your Phone

Most phones have a built-in editor that's all you need:

Brightness: +10 to +20 (make it feel airy)

Contrast: +5 to +10

Saturation: -5 to 0 (keep colours accurate)

Free apps: Snapseed (Android/iOS) or Lightroom Mobile (free tier is excellent).

Common Mistakes to Avoid

- Cluttered backgrounds — keep it simple
- Products too small in frame — fill the frame
- Inconsistent style across your shop — pick one background and stick with it
- Over-editing — buyers want accurate colours